Lesson 35

LAST DAYS SERIES – THE RAPTURE OF THE CHURCH

Aim: To teach the believers the biblical teaching of the first phase of the second coming of Christ, the Rapture.

Introduction:

“Are you ready for the rapture of the church”

“Are you ready for Heaven”

Our Lord Jesus Christ now wants all Christians to get into a sense of urgency in our preparation for His second coming.”— Doris Ijeoma Basil, A Sense of Urgency

The word " Rapture" is derived from the latin word "Raptu". Which means " caught away or caught up". This latin word is equivalent to the Greek word "Harpaze" translated as "caught up" in 1 Thessalonians 4:17

"17 After that, we who are still alive and are left will be caught up together with them in the clouds to meet the Lord in the air. And so we will be with the Lord for ever."

This event, described here and in 1 Corinthians 15, refers to the catching up of the church from the earth to meet the Lord in the air. It involves only the faithful of Christ's churches.

The Stages of the Rapture

1. Just prior to the Rapture, as Christ is descending from heaven for His church, the resurrection of the “Dead in Christ" will occur 1 Thessalonians 4:16 16For the Lord himself will come down from heaven, with a loud command, with the voice of the archangel and with the trumpet call of God, and the dead in Christ will rise first.

This is not the same resurrection described in (*Rev. 20:4 “I saw thrones on which were seated those who had been given authority to judge. And I saw the souls of those who had been beheaded because of their testimony about Jesus and because of the word of God. They had not worshiped the beast or its image and had not received its mark on their foreheads or their hands. They came to life and reigned with Christ a thousand years.*-) for the latter is an event occurring after Christ returns to earth, destroys

the wicked and binds Satan (*Rev. 19:11 “11I saw heaven standing open and there before me was a white horse, whose rider is called Faithful and True. With justice he judges and wages war." 3He threw him into the Abyss, and locked and sealed it over him, to keep him from deceiving the nations anymore until the thousand years were ended. After that, he must be set free for a short time.– Rev. 20:3*). The resurrection in Rev. 20:4 relates to the martyred dead of the tribulation and possibly to OT saints (Rev. 20:6)

2. At the same time as the dead in Christ will rise, living believers will be transfigured, their bodies will be clothed with immortality. (1Cor. 15:51,53 51Listen, I tell you a mystery: We will not all sleep, but we will all be changed52in a flash, in the twinkling of an eye, at the last trumpet. For the trumpet will sound, the dead will be raised imperishable, and Page | 18 we will be changed. 53For the perishable must clothe itself with the imperishable, and the mortal with immortality)

This will happen in a very short time," In the twinkling of an eye" (I Co. 15:52)

3. Both the resurrected believers and the transfigured believers will be caught up together to meet Christ in the air.,. In the atmosphere between heaven and the earth.

4. They will be visibly united with Christ.

1 Thess. 4;16-17, taken to His Father's house in heaven

John 14:2-3 and united with loved who have died.

1 Thess. 4:13-18

1Thessalonians 4:16-17 16For the Lord himself will come down from heaven, with a loud command, with the voice of the archangel and with the trumpet call of God, and the dead in Christ will rise first. 17After that, we who are still alive and are left will be caught up together with them in the clouds to meet the Lord in the air. And so we will be with the Lord forever.

5. They will be removed from all distress (2 Co. 5:2,4, Phil. 3:21)

2 Corinthians 5:2,4 2 Meanwhile we groan, longing to be clothed instead with our heavenly dwelling,

4 For while we are in this tent, we groan and are burdened, because we do not wish to be unclothed but to

be clothed instead with our heavenly dwelling, so that what is mortal may be swallowed up by life.

Philippians 3:21 21 who, by the power that enables him to bring everything under his control, will transform our lowly bodies so that they will be like his glorious body.

From all persecution and oppression (Rev. 3:10), from the entire sin and death (1 Cor.15:51-56) Christ thereby delivers them from " the wrath to come" 1 Thess. 1:10, 5:9) from the great tribulation.

Revelations 3:20 20Here I am! I stand at the door and knock. If anyone hears my voice and opens the door, I will come in and eat with that person, and they with me.

1 Corinthians 15:51-56 51Listen, I tell you a mystery: We will not all sleep, but we will all be changed— 52in a flash, in the twinkling of an eye, at the last trumpet. For the trumpet will sound, the dead will be raised imperishable, and we will be changed. 53For the perishable must clothe itself with the imperishable, and the mortal with immortality. 54When the perishable has been clothed with the imperishable, and the mortal with immortality, then the saying that is written will come true: "Death has been swallowed up in victory." 55"Where, O death, is your victory? Where, O death, is your

sting?”56The sting of death is sin, and the power of sin is the law.

1 Thess. 1:10 10 and to wait for his Son from heaven, whom he raised from the dead—Jesus, who rescues us from the coming wrath. 9 For God did not appoint us to suffer wrath but to receive salvation through our Lord Jesus Christ.

6. The hope that our Savior will soon return to take us out if the world to "ever be with the Lord" (1 Thess. 4:17) is the blessed hope of the redeemed (Titus 2:13) and a major source of comfort for suffering believers (1 Thes 4:17-18, 5:10)

Titus 2:13 “13while we wait for the blessed hope—the appearing of the glory of our great God and Savior, Jesus Christ,”

1Thessaloninas 4:17, 5:10 17After that, we who are still alive and are left will be caught up together with them in the clouds to meet the Lord in the air. And so we will be with the Lord forever. 18Therefore encourage one another with these words.

5:10 He died for us so that, whether we are awake or asleep, we may live together with him.

7. Paul uses "we" in 1Thes 4:17 because he knows the Lord's return could have happened in his own lifetime, and he communicates this same anticipation to the Thessalonians. The Bible insists on a continual waiting with eagerness for the return of the Lord. Believers today must be ever watchful and hopeful for Christ's return to take them to Himself (cf. Rom 13:11; 1 Cor 7:29; 10:11; 15:51-52; Phil 4:5)

Rom13:11 11And do this, understanding the present time: The hour has already come for you to wake up from your slumber, because our salvation is nearer now than when we first believed.

1 Corinthians 7:29, 10:11, 15:51, 29 What I mean, brothers and sisters, is that the time is short. From now on those who have wives should live as if they do not;

8. According to this view of the rapture, professing Christians who do not have a saving relationship with Christ will be left behind (see Mat 25:1, note; see article on The Age of the Antichrist, p. 1912), and be subject to God’s wrath. Matthew 25:1 “At that time the kingdom of

heaven will be like ten virgins who took their lamps and went out to meet the bridegroom.

9. Following the rapture is the day of the Lord, a time that brings distress and wrath to the ungodly (1 Thes 5:2-10; see 5:2, note). That will be followed by the second stage of Christ's coming, when He comes to destroy the ungodly and to reign on earth (see Mat 24:42,44 notes).

1Thessalonians 5:2-10 2for you know very well that the day of the Lord will come like a thief in the night. 3While people are saying, "Peace and safety," destruction will come on them suddenly, as labor pains on a pregnant woman, and they will not escape.4But you, brothers and sisters, are not in darkness so that this day should surprise you like a thief.5You are all children of the light and children of the day. We do not belong to the night or to the darkness. 6So then, let us not be like others, who are asleep, but let us be awake and sober. 7For those who sleep, sleep at night, and those who get drunk, get drunk at night. 8But since we belong to the day, let us be sober, putting on faith and love as a breastplate, and the hope of salvation as a helmet. 9For God did not appoint us to suffer wrath but to receive salvation through our Lord

Jesus Christ. 10He died for us so that, whether we are awake or asleep, we may live together with him.